

Week 3

Communicating with Faculty

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Today's icebreaker

Would you be an assistant for an extremely famous person, even if you knew they were difficult to work with? Explain why or why not.

JP's response

- ▶ Probably
 - ▶ Because I never learn

Elevator pitch

- ▶ 1-2 minute pitch including:
 - ▶ who you are
 - ▶ your background
 - ▶ your project idea
 - ▶ projections for the future (how project will help your academic career)
 - ▶ OR a question for the person

JP's pitch

- ▶ Jonathan A. Pedroza, but you can call me JP
- ▶ I am postdoctoral researcher in data science education
- ▶ My background is in Prevention Science where
- ▶ Interest in use of diagnostic classification models
 - ▶ Within alternative grading methods, such as mastery grading
 - ▶ As tool to assess mastery of course concepts early and make education more equitable
 - ▶ Specifically in data science and statistics courses
- ▶ My hope is this project could lead to building tools for faculty, as well as:
 - ▶ papers
 - ▶ presentations
 - ▶ public scholarship for college educators

Practice

- ▶ Give it a shot with a small group around you
- ▶ 1-2 minute pitch including:
 - ▶ who you are
 - ▶ your background
 - ▶ your project idea
 - ▶ projections for the future (how project will help your academic career)
 - ▶ OR a question for the person

Reaching out to advisors

- ▶ What worries you most about reaching out to advisors?

Reaching out to advisors

- ▶ What worries you most about reaching out to advisors?
 - ▶ They are an expert in their field
 - ▶ They hold a position of power over me
 - ▶ What if they think my idea is stupid?
 - ▶ I'm wasting their time and they are busy
 - ▶ What if they don't respond?

Reaching out to advisors

- ▶ They are an expert in their field
 - ▶ They are an expert ONLY in their field
 - ▶ This expertise in their field means they probably struggle with other skills

Reaching out to advisors

- ▶ They hold a position of power over me
 - ▶ Power is relative
 - ▶ They hold power over you in this *specific* field
 - ▶ If an advisor is getting food and they are being rude
 - ▶ Are they still in power?

Reaching out to advisors

- ▶ What if they think my idea is stupid?
 - ▶ Rethink if your research interests match their research
 - ▶ Otherwise, this is a red flag
 - ▶ Advisors should be able to shift your interests to be realistic and align with their work if the fit is somewhat there

Reaching out to advisors

- ▶ I'm wasting their time and they are busy
 - ▶ If an advisor doesn't have time for you that is okay
 - ▶ You find a new advisor
 - ▶ Also, you're not wasting their time
 - ▶ Advisors are academics because they love advancing research
 - ▶ If interests align, most will show interest

Reaching out to advisors

- ▶ What if they don't respond?
 - ▶ They may not
 - ▶ Check back in after a week with follow-up email
 - ▶ If no response, look for a new advisor

Points about advisors

- ▶ Remember, all potential advisors are people
- ▶ Don't choose advisors based on the name
 - ▶ Pick based on fit with their research
 - ▶ Pick based on faculty's level of commitment/availability
 - ▶ Don't bad mouth people (i.e., advisors)
- ▶ Both interested in similar topics
 - ▶ Don't be afraid to be excited
 - ▶ Excited is great

This is a relationship

- ▶ This is academic dating
 - ▶ You may get rejected
- ▶ Just like romantic relationships
 - ▶ You have a voice
- ▶ Toxic relationships
 - ▶ Would you date someone famous and toxic?



Photo by Israyosoy S

How to reach most faculty

- ▶ Emails
- ▶ Office hours
- ▶ Meeting at departmental social event
- ▶ If you don't know someone AT ALL
 - ▶ Don't give pitch if you see them in public
 - ▶ If you took a class with them, say hi, then you can email them

We'll focus on emails

- ▶ Don't use AI
- ▶ Seriously don't use AI
- ▶ Show your genuine interest
- ▶ What goes into your email

We'll focus on emails

- ▶ State who you are
- ▶ Background (Senior in DS & _____)
- ▶ Show interest
 - ▶ What about their research interests you
 - ▶ Read publications
- ▶ Mention how your project idea connects with their research
- ▶ What do you want out of the meeting (DS Advisor)
- ▶ When can they meet & your availability
- ▶ Closing statement/Thank them for their time

Focal points of email

- ▶ There's a lot that goes into it
 - ▶ Try to make it short
- ▶ NEVER WRITE A DRAFT IN THE EMAIL
- ▶ If reaching out to multiple advisors
 - ▶ Don't copy + paste without some sort of system
- ▶ Reread your email
- ▶ Actually read about their research AND AT LEAST 1 PUBLICATION

What to read in their articles

- ▶ Find their Google Scholar
 - ▶ Check this against their faculty/lab website
 - ▶ Choose the article that sounds interesting to you
- ▶ Find something that matches to your idea
 - ▶ Article Example

Meeting with your (potential) advisor

- ▶ Be prepared when you meet with your advisor
 - ▶ Come with agenda
 - ▶ Recurring meetings (weekly vs biweekly)
 - ▶ Send email with meeting notes
 - ▶ Cancel if you don't have updates
 - ▶ Do this sparingly
- ▶ Know when it is your time to leave
 - ▶ When agenda is complete, check in on anything else lingering



Photo by Ketut Subiyanto

Being prepared for your meeting

- ▶ What goes into your agenda
 - ▶ PhD, EdD, or other doctorate = Refer to them as Dr. always
 - ▶ Be human
 - ▶ Little conversation
 - ▶ Explain your advisor idea OR
 - ▶ Ask about any project ideas the advisor has
 - ▶ What would they be willing to help you build an independent project around
 - ▶ What is needed from you (trainings)
 - ▶ Ask if they have seminal/crucial research that you should read
 - ▶ Your assignments (getting approval of RQs & agreement on timeline)

“Small talk” for meeting with advisor

- ▶ “How is your semester going?”
- ▶ “Thanks for making time to have me here”
- ▶ “I like your office”
 - ▶ “Oh that is a cool _____ {notice something in their office}”
- ▶ Chat about anything
 - ▶ Advisors are human
 - ▶ You’re gonna have a relationship with them

Be prepared to change

- ▶ NEVER fall in love with your research idea
 - ▶ Destined for failure
- ▶ Your idea will adapt from your original project
- ▶ It could adapt as you read more literature
- ▶ It may adapt because you don't have the capabilities to answer RQs
 - ▶ Data doesn't answer the question
 - ▶ You don't have the expertise to analyze it
 - ▶ Many other reasons
- ▶ Be realistic and kind to yourself